Jewish thought sees them as two utterly unrelated books and simply refuses to acknowledge that there might be a single book encompassing both, even though it is probably the most common book in the world.

It is crucial to note that the people who created the New Testament weren't the authors of the twenty-seven texts it contains; they were the curators. Due to the paucity of evidence from the period, we do not know if Athanasius's list of texts reflected his personal judgement, or whether it originated with earlier Christian thinkers. What we do know is that prior to the Councils of Hippo and Carthage there were rival recommendation lists for Christians. The earliest such list was codified by Marcion of Sinope in the middle of the second century. The Marcion canon included only the Gospel of Luke and ten epistles of Paul. Even these eleven texts were somewhat different from the versions later canonised at Hippo and Carthage. Either Marcion was unaware of other texts like the Gospel of John and the book of Revelation, or he did not think highly of them.[48]

The church father Saint John Chrysostom, a contemporary of Bishop Athanasius's, recommended only twenty-two books, leaving 2 Peter, 2 John, 3 John, Jude and Revelation out of his list.[49] Some Christian churches in the Middle East to this day follow Chrysostom's shorter list.[50] The Armenian Church took about a thousand years to make up its mind about the book of Revelation, while it included in its canon the Third Epistle to the Corinthians, which other churches – like the Catholic and Protestant churches – consider a forgery.[51] The Ethiopian Church endorsed Athanasius's list in full, but added four other books: Sinodos, the book of Clement, the book of the Covenant and the Didascalia.[52] Other lists endorsed the two epistles of Clement, the visions of the Shepherd of Hermas, the Epistle of Barnabas, the Apocalypse of Peter and various other texts that didn't make it into Athanasius's selection.[53]

We do not know the precise reasons why specific texts were endorsed or rejected by different churches, church councils and church fathers. But the consequences were far-reaching. While churches made decisions about texts, the texts themselves shaped the churches. As a key example, consider the role of women in the church. Some early Christian leaders saw women as intellectually and ethically inferior to men, and argued that women should be restricted to subordinate roles in society and in the Christian